

Accepted Terminology Guide

When discussing Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples in INDG6002, there are several respectful terms you may use. List of terms which are acceptable, you MUST choose one term and use it consistently throughout your assessment. The only time it is considered appropriate to change – is in a direct quote.

Acceptable terms

- Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander P/peoples
- Indigenous P/peoples
- Indigenous Australian P/peoples
- Australian Indigenous P/peoples
- First Nations P/peoples

Capitalising

Each of these terms MUST be capitalised (as per 'Gnibi Academic communication style' / 'Respectful terminology and language' in Welcome to Gnibi Module)

Peoples

The word 'peoples' is the only word students can choose to capitalise OR not. Also, it must be plural – 'peoples' with the 's' AND it MUST be consistent.

Respectful Tone

Tone refers to the attitude, emotional quality, and level of respect communicated through your language choices. It is not just *what* you say, but *how* you say it. When discussing Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, cultures, knowledges, and communities, tone is critically important because it signals whether you are approaching the topic with **respect, cultural humility, and awareness of historical and ongoing injustices**. A culturally safe tone avoids assumptions, stereotypes, and deficit language; it centres strengths, sovereignty, and lived experience; and it acknowledges that these knowledges are not simply "content" but belong to real communities with deep histories and continuing cultural authority. Using an appropriate tone helps build trust, demonstrates ethical engagement, and ensures that your writing honours the significance of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives rather than speaking over, minimising, or misrepresenting them.



Apostrophes

When using **“Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples”** in a possessive sense, **do not add an apostrophe**. The term **“Peoples”** names multiple distinct cultural groups and is treated as a **proper noun** in respectful academic and governmental usage. Adding an apostrophe can imply ownership or introduce meanings that are culturally inappropriate.

Correct:

- **“Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples mental health”**

Not preferred:

- **“Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander People’s mental health”**

The plural **“Peoples”** refers to several distinct groups, helping avoid homogenising diverse First Nations communities. It is capitalised when referring to specific cultural groups, as in **“Indigenous Peoples.”**

When adding another phrase

“Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples” is the correct term when you are talking about the many distinct First Nations peoples collectively.

But when you add another word after it — like *health*, *culture*, *knowledges*, *histories*, or *worldviews* — you **remove “Peoples”** and use the shorter form:

- **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander health**
- **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures**
- **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander knowledges**
- **Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander histories**